Lesson 15: Choosing Quotes and Analyzing a Text

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.9: Choosing Quotes and Analyzing a Text.

In this lesson

You will choose a powerful quotation from a sociology text about the Dreamers, respond to it, study a model analysis, and look closely at how the sample reading response journal from Lesson 11 quotes, analyzes and changes quotations correctly. Analysis, explaining why a passage matters, is what university teachers expect in essays and discussion posts, not only a summary.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose a meaningful, surprising or thought-provoking quotation, and explain your choice.
- Respond to a quotation with sentence frames, and rewrite the response as formal analysis.
- Explain the significance of a quotation through connections to yourself, other texts and the world.
- Use square brackets, ellipses and single quotation marks correctly inside quotations.
- Use the present tense for what an author writes and the past tense for past events.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
analyze / analysis	study something carefully to understand it more deeply / the result of this study	To analyze something means to study it carefully with the purpose of understanding it more deeply.
significance	why something matters; its deeper meaning	We want to explain the significance of it.
text-to-self / text-to-text / text-to-world	a connection to your own life / to another text / to events in the world	Make connections (text-to-self, text-to-text, text-to-world).
imply	suggest something without saying it directly	Here, the author seems to imply that …
emphasize	give special importance to	As Gutierrez, et al. emphasize, it is critical that youth hear the voices of other immigrants.
advocate	a person who speaks publicly for a cause; (verb) to speak publicly for a cause	Writers like Vargas and Grande have used their voices to advocate for change.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
et al.	"and others": used for a source with three or more authors	Erika Gutierrez et al. state that ...
square brackets [ ]	mark words you changed or added inside a quotation	"[d]espite the fact that ..."
ellipsis (. . .)	marks words you left out of a quotation	"that pit of self-deprecation . . . and into a good college"
quotation within a quotation	a quotation inside another quotation; in American English it uses single quotation marks	... recognized at school as 'Gifted and Talented.'

Rules and explanations

Choosing and responding to a quotation

- Choose a phrase, sentence or group of sentences that speaks to you: meaningful, surprising or thought-provoking (making you think seriously). Ask why it speaks to you, and how it connects to you (experiences, values, beliefs), to other texts or to the world (news, politics).
- Sentence frames (fixed patterns to complete) for a response:
  - When I read, "X" (Gutierrez et al), I wondered if Y. / I thought about Y.
  - I chose: "X" (Gutierrez et al). My question is, Y? / I made a connection with Y.
  - I chose "X" (Gutierrez et al) because Y.

What is analysis?

- To analyze is to explain the significance of a text: What is the deeper meaning? Why does it matter? We do this every day, with reviews, podcasts, songs and memes.
- When we analyze, we might ask questions, make predictions, draw conclusions, identify problems and propose solutions, make connections (text-to-self, text-to-text, text-to-world), discuss opinions, and agree or disagree.
- Academic analysis uses the same thinking, but it is usually written in the third person and does not talk directly about our experience as readers.

Informal response	Formal analysis
I chose this quote because I think ...	This situation is similar to ...
This story reminds me of ...	Because of the impact of X, ...
I wonder why ...	Here, the author seems to imply that ...

Changing a quotation correctly

Mark	Use
[ ]	You change or add words so that the quotation fits your sentence: a capital letter, a verb ending, a pronoun.
. . .	You leave out words that you do not need. The meaning must not change.
' '	A quotation inside your quotation: the original double quotation marks become single ones.

- Tense: use the present tense for what an author does in the text (Fuentes-Mena explains, contrasts, writes), because the text still speaks to us now. Use the past tense for events in the past (He felt worthless; President Trump announced an end to DACA in 2017).

> **In psychology (APA style):** a direct quotation needs the author, the year and a page number, or a paragraph number for a text without pages: (Gutierrez et al., 2021, para. 2). The book's frames give only the authors (Gutierrez et al), as MLA style does for texts without pages. Psychology writers also paraphrase more often than they quote, and keep quotations for wording that really matters.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no capital letters, so notice "[d]espite": the writer changed the capital D to a small d, in brackets, because the quotation continues their own sentence.

Practice

Exercise 1. Choose and respond to a quotation. Read "The Dreamers" by Erika Gutierrez et al. in the lesson material. Choose a phrase, sentence or group of sentences that speaks to you. Write a response with one of the five sentence frames.

Exercise 2. Study an analysis. Read the quotation from "The Dreamers" and its analysis under "Analysis example".

1. Which is longer, the quotation or the analysis?
2. In the analysis, how does the writer connect to their own knowledge, other texts, or the world?
3. Is the analysis an informal response or formal analysis? How do you know?

Exercise 3. Analyze the reading response journal. Read "Deport Me" and the sample reading response journal (Table 1.2.1) again, in the Lesson 11 material. Then answer the book's questions. (Discuss questions 1 and 10 with your tutor.)

1. Which of the four responses are most interesting to you? Why?
2. Which of these methods of analysis did the journal writer use in each of the four entries? (ask questions; make predictions; draw conclusions; identify problems and propose solutions; make connections: text-to-self, text-to-text, text-to-world; discuss opinions; agree/disagree)
3. Does the journal writer use the author's first name, last name, or both in the responses?
4. What reporting verbs does the journal writer use?

5. Can you find examples of quoting, paraphrasing, summarizing, and analysis in the four entries? Which does the journal writer use most? Why did the journal writer decide to use short quotations for certain phrases or sentences instead of just paraphrasing them?
6. Can you find examples of square brackets ([ ]) and ellipses (. . .) in the journals? Why did the writer use these?
7. In entry 2, the journal writer uses a quotation that includes the phrase "Gifted and Talented". How do they change the quotation marks to show that this is a quotation within a quotation?
8. In entry 2, when does the journal writer use present tense and when do they use past tense?
9. In entry 4, how does the journal writer change the pronouns "me", "my", and "myself" in the quotation? Why do they do this?
10. How could you use this example to help you with your own textual analyses?

Speak with your tutor

- "I will tell you about a song, speech or piece of writing that is powerful for me. Ask me why it is powerful, and help me turn my answer into analysis."
- "Here is the quotation I chose from 'The Dreamers' and my response: [paste]. Ask me two follow-up questions that push me from a personal response to an analysis."
- "Here is my informal response: [paste]. Help me rewrite it as formal analysis in the third person, starting with 'Here, the authors seem to imply that ...'."
- "Give me three long quotations from a PSYC 110 lecture. I will shorten each with an ellipsis and change a pronoun with square brackets. Check my changes."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 3 about the sample reading response journal."

Read aloud

1. To analyze something means to study it carefully with the purpose of understanding it more deeply.
2. Here, the authors seem to imply that sharing their stories gave young immigrants the courage to demand change.
3. As Gutierrez, et al. emphasize, it is critical that youth hear the voices of other immigrants.
4. Writers like Jose Antonio Vargas and Reyna Grande have used their voices to advocate for change.
5. Word stress: AN·a·lyze, a·NAL·y·sis, sig·NIF·i·cance, EM·pha·size, im·PLY, AD·vo·cate.

Writing task

Your own analysis paragraph. First write a one-sentence informal response with a sentence frame; then write a formal paragraph of 150-200 words that analyzes the quotation. Choose one:

- From "The Dreamers": "For this subgroup of undocumented immigrants, the narrative was convincing: they were socialized in U.S. schools, were not familiar with any other country, they played by the rules, and therefore had the right to pursue the American dream." (The material prints "compelling convincing", an editing leftover; quote "convincing", as in the reading.)

- From "The Dreamers": "According to a June 2020 Pew survey, 74% of Americans support granting legal status to immigrants who were brought to the U.S. without legal papers as children, but on September 5, 2017, President Trump announced an end to DACA" (Edelman, 2017). (The material prints "illegally without legal papers"; the reading says "without legal papers".)
- A quotation from a PSYC 110 lecture, for example Lecture 20, "The Good Life: Happiness".

Note: the reading calls DACA "a new law" and also "this policy". DACA was a government policy, not a law passed by Congress; call it a policy or a program.

Checklist:

- The quotation is introduced with the authors' names and a reporting verb, copied exactly, and cited (Gutierrez et al.).
- Your analysis is much longer than the quotation and explains its significance: the deeper meaning and why it matters.
- You make at least one connection: text-to-self, text-to-text or text-to-world.
- You use formal analysis starters and the third person (no "I think").
- Any change inside the quotation is in square brackets; any words left out are marked with an ellipsis.
- Present tense for what the authors write; past tense for past events.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answers)

- When I read, "They learned that there was nothing to be ashamed of" (Gutierrez et al), I thought about how talking with people who share a problem can turn shame into strength.
- I chose: "As of March 2020, there are 643,560 DACA recipients who at least temporarily have some sense of stability and opportunity that they did not have previously" (Gutierrez et al). My question is, why did only about half of the 1.3 million people who qualified become recipients?

Exercise 2

1. The analysis is much longer: about 210 words, compared with about 40 words for the quotation. An analysis explains and connects, so it is usually longer than the quotation it discusses.
2. Other texts: Reyna Grande's books (she wrote them because she could not find books that told her story) and her letter in The New York Times. The world: the family separations at the U.S.-Mexican border and Ivanka Trump's comment blaming the parents; Grande's proposals (pathways to asylum, foreign aid for Mexico's economy) identify problems and propose solutions. Own knowledge: details of Grande's life (her father left when she was two). The last sentence draws a conclusion: writers like Vargas and Grande use their voices to advocate for change.
3. Formal analysis: it is written in the third person, with no "I"; it reports the authors' ideas with verbs such as "emphasize" and "pointed out"; it connects the quotation to other texts and events instead of describing the writer's feelings.

Exercise 3

1. (example answer) Entry 3 is the most interesting to me, because it shows how short sentences and rhyme can create a rhythm that holds the reader's attention.
2. More than one answer is possible. Entry 1: draws conclusions (the word "home" is symbolic; the opening builds empathy) and makes a connection (we have all been eight years old). Entry 2: draws conclusions (the impact of his parents' status was stronger than his successes) and discusses an opinion ("It's terrible that he felt shame"). Entry 3: draws conclusions about repetition, rhyme and sentence length, and gives an opinion (humans should not have a price). Entry 4: makes a text-to-self connection (the writer's teacher, Professor Lee) and draws a conclusion (one teacher can make a big difference).
3. The last name only: "Fuentes-Mena" (and "the author", "he").
4. To introduce quotations: recalls (entry 1), explains (2), writes (3), reports (4), and "As Fuentes-Mena said" (4). Inside the responses the writer also uses verbs such as contrasts, describes, repeats, uses and shows.
5. Quoting: every Quotation column, and short quotations inside the responses ("a real home of our own", "half-priced human beings"). Paraphrase or summary: the introduction to the entry 2 quotation and the first sentence of the entry 2 response ("After seeing how his father and mother each worked all weekend for low pay, ..."). Analysis: most of every response, so it is used most.

Short quotations keep the exact words when the analysis is about those words (the word "home", repetition, rhyme); a paraphrase would lose them.

6. Square brackets: "[d]espite" (entry 2); "chasing [his] dreams" (entry 3 response); "[him]", "[his]", "[he]", "[himself]" (entry 4 quotation); "remind[ed]" (entry 4 response). They show words the writer changed so that the quotation fits their sentence. Ellipses: "Despite the fact . . ." (entry 2 response); "self-deprecation . . . and into a good college" (entry 4 quotation); "telling me . . . was wrong" (entry 4 response). They show that words were left out.
7. The original's double quotation marks ("Gifted and Talented") become single quotation marks ('Gifted and Talented') inside the double quotation marks of the journal.
8. Present tense for what Fuentes-Mena does as a writer and for the journal writer's comments: explains, contrasts, writes, emphasizes, shows, "It's terrible". Past tense for events and feelings in his childhood: did not feel valued, worked, internalized, was more powerful, felt shame.
9. "me" becomes "[him]", "my" becomes "[his]" and "myself" becomes "[himself]" (and "I" becomes "[he]"). The journal writer reports in the third person ("Fuentes-Mena reports that he ..."), so the pronouns must agree with the sentence; the brackets show the changes.
10. (example answer) I can quote only the words I want to analyze, introduce each quotation with the author's last name and a reporting verb, and use brackets and ellipses to fit quotations into my sentences.

My notes